

RFI GLOBAL
Intelligence to bank on

FINANCIAL SERVICES
**Trends and
Predictions
2026**

Data-driven intelligence on the
five trends set to shape 2026



Introduction

2025 has been another year of rapid transformation in financial services. The acceleration of AI and digital technologies has changed how consumers and businesses interact with financial providers, while economic uncertainty and the continued rise of fintechs have shifted expectations of value, loyalty and service.

Our data shows that markets continue to evolve at different speeds, with priorities shaped by regulation, infrastructure and customer behaviour. Payment preferences highlight this divergence: mobile wallets are near-universal in APAC, the UK still clings to cash, the US relies on traditional cards, and Australia has more readily embraced BNPL than most markets. Adoption of digital-only providers has also varied. In Australia, early challengers have been absorbed by incumbents; in the UK, neobanks are entering a new phase of maturity, and in the US, momentum is finally building.

AI is at the centre of these changes, acting as both an opportunity and a risk. Customers are more comfortable using AI-powered tools to help manage their finances, yet the same technologies raise new challenges for security, accuracy and fraud prevention.

Wealth dynamics are also shifting. The influence of the affluent, and a new generation of ultra-wealthy, is reshaping demand for investment services. They expect tailored solutions, digital sophistication and global capabilities, creating opportunities for providers ready to adapt.

At the same time, expectations of digital user experience are rising sharply. Customers increasingly demand seamless, personalised interactions across every channel, from onboarding to servicing, and they are more willing to switch providers if their expectations aren't met. Social media is also becoming a mainstream

gateway to financial research, signalling a fundamental shift in how advice is sought and trusted.

To help financial institutions prepare for 2026, we've analysed our data from over 200,000 consumers and 60,000 businesses worldwide, and thousands of real interactions with banking apps. This booklet highlights the five key trends we believe will define the year ahead and data-driven predictions to help you anticipate change, meet customer needs and capture growth opportunities in an increasingly competitive landscape.



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5 trends shaping the future of financial services

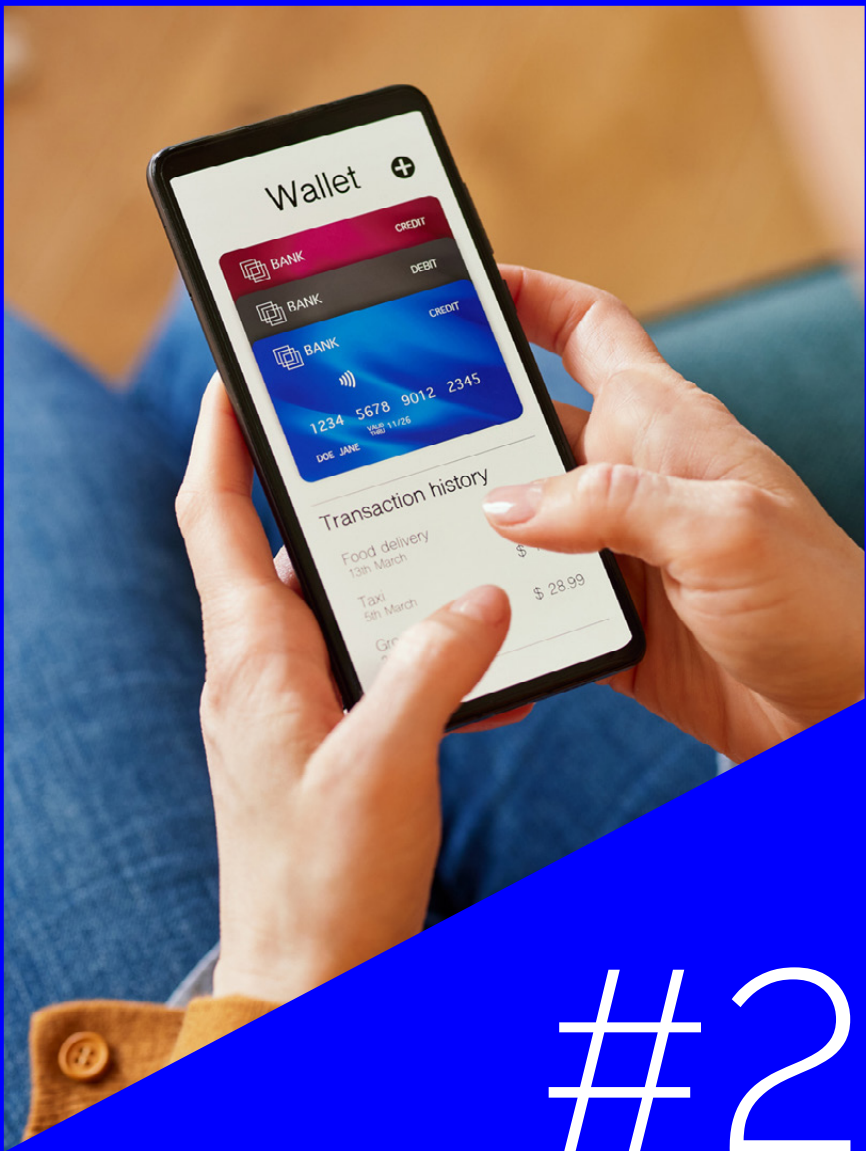


#1

From curiosity to confidence: Building trust in AI-powered finance

AI is rapidly moving from novelty to necessity in financial services. While customer adoption varies across markets, trust and transparency remain the key to unlocking growth. Banks that balance innovation with reassurance will be best placed to gain confidence and loyalty as AI reshapes banking.

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#2

Digital user experience (UX): The key battleground for customer loyalty

As digital banking evolves, user experience has become the ultimate differentiator. The most successful institutions are those delivering seamless, secure and intuitive digital journeys that empower customers, strengthen trust and build long-term loyalty in an increasingly competitive landscape.

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#3

The next chapter for neobanks: From growth to value

Neobanks are shifting focus from rapid customer base growth to attaining sustainable profitability through deeper customer engagement. By expanding product offerings, leveraging technology and forming strategic partnerships, they're evolving into full-service institutions. This strategic pivot positions them to capture greater wallet share, strengthen relationships and reshape customer expectations in a more competitive financial landscape.

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#4

Cybersecurity: Fraud has evolved, but have banks?

Fraud is evolving faster than ever, driven by AI, digital tools and sophisticated scams. Financial institutions face rising challenges in security, fraud detection and customer protection, while customers demand seamless, trustworthy experiences. Harnessing data, AI and cross-industry collaboration will be key to staying ahead in 2026.

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#5

Wealth in 2026: Unlocking fee-based growth as affluent investments rise

As interest rates decrease, affluent consumers are reallocating funds from savings into investments, signalling a global resurgence in wealth activity. In this environment, banks will increasingly turn to fee-based income to deepen client relationships and grow profitability. Discover what's driving this shift, and the barriers to capturing fee-based growth.

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Trend #1

From curiosity to confidence: Building trust in AI-powered finance

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AI has moved firmly into the mainstream, shaping how people search, shop, work - and increasingly, how they manage their money.

Weekly users of ChatGPT increased by +1,500% in the last two years, making it the world's fifth most visited website*. As consumers become more accustomed to AI in everyday life, banks are embedding AI into day-to-day customer interactions.

Trust is the largest hurdle to overcome in AI adoption. Most consumers in Singapore (95%), Australia (94%) and Canada (94%) have concerns about using AI with their bank, with privacy and data security topping the

list. Fear of misleading or incorrect advice is a concern for 30% of Australians. In the US, 84% of consumers voice concerns about AI, and across North America, consumers have privacy and security top of mind and are fearful that overreliance on AI will lead to fewer opportunities for human interaction and expertise. Similarly, two-fifths of consumers in Malaysia and Singapore worry about privacy and the accuracy of AI-based decision-making.



US

A third of Americans (32%) say regular audits would make them more comfortable with AI-powered financial services, with 54% concerned about the accuracy of AI-based decision-making. Transparency and bias checks would help to build trust.

Source: RFI Global MacroMonitor, US household survey

32%

Say regular audits would make them more comfortable with AI-powered financial services

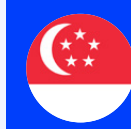
54%

Are concerned about the accuracy of AI-based decision-making



Consumers with any concern about AI-powered financial services

Singapore



95%

Australia



94%

Canada



94%

Malaysia



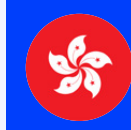
93%

US



84%

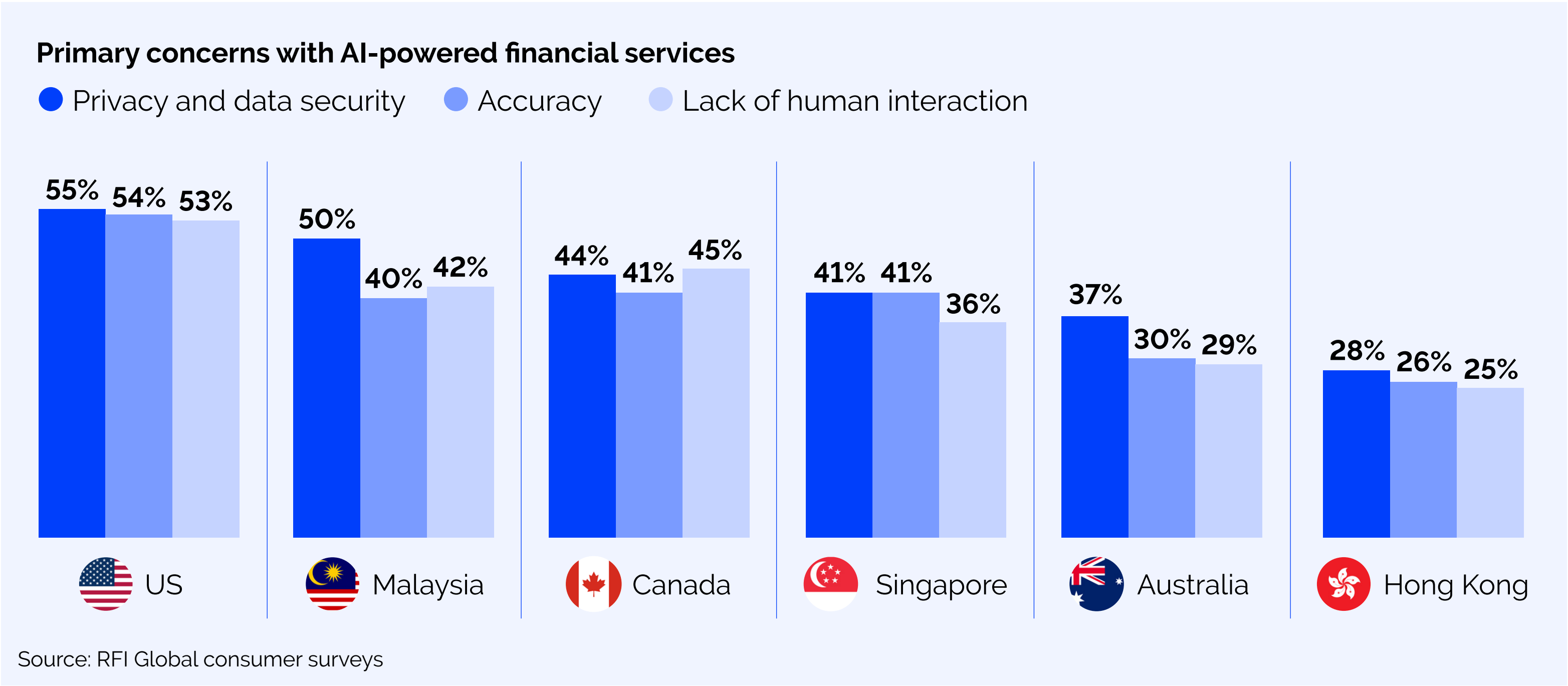
Hong Kong



80%

Source: RFI Global surveys

Trend #1 **From curiosity to confidence**



Consumer interest in AI banking tools varies significantly by market. Consumers in Hong Kong, Malaysia and Singapore are most open to AI-based virtual assistants, fraud detection and AI predicting customer behaviour, with around 75% expressing interest.

By contrast, consumers in Canada, Australia and the US are more hesitant, with less interest in the use of AI, except for fraud detection. In markets with lower interest, banks need to educate customers to make them more comfortable with AI for banking, research and day-to-

day queries. In Australia, only 1 in 10 consumers use AI to research products - but more than half say they would be interested in using it for product comparison tasks, revealing the potential of AI in choosing financial products.

AI will also expose consumers to more products and brands, levelling the playing field for smaller institutions competing with major players. This aligns with recent research on usage of ChatGPT from the Bureau of Economic Research*, indicating 21% of all ChatGPT prompts globally are to seek information.



Canadians are most concerned about the lack of personal touch when using AI for financial services (45%) and are least comfortable with robo-advisors (36%). A blended approach to AI integration is best.

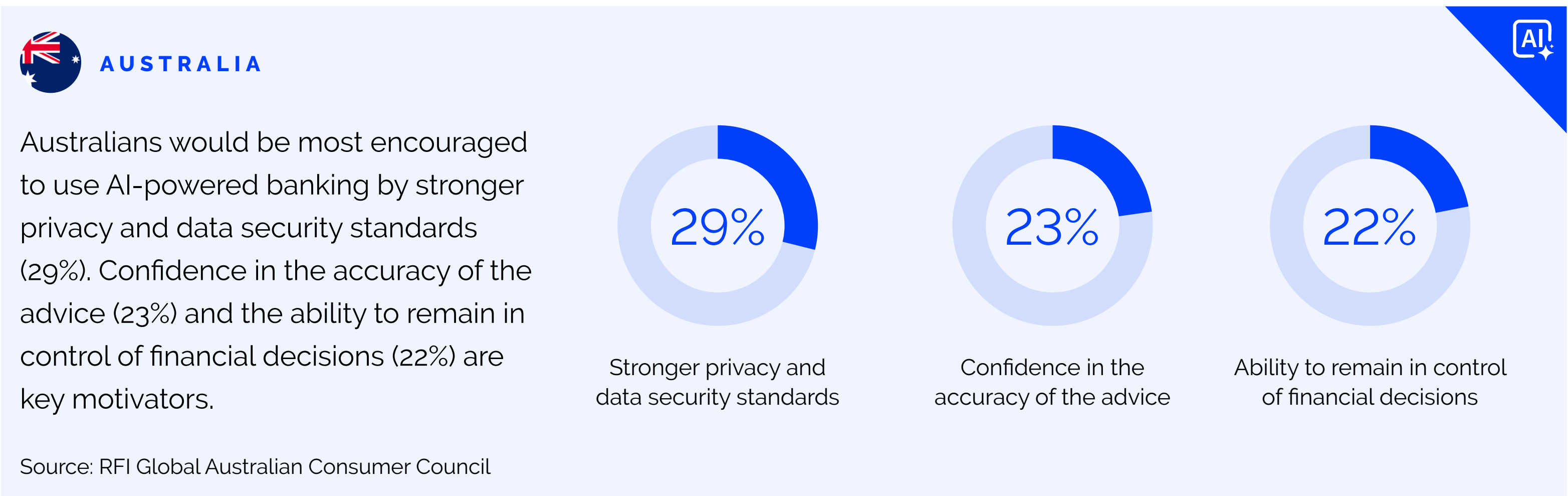
Source: RFI Global Canadian Consumer Council



Hong Kong consumers lead in openness to AI in banking, over half are at ease with AI-powered fraud detection (54%) and loan approval (52%), compared with lower comfort in Singapore (40%) and Malaysia (44%).

Source: RFI Global APAC Consumer Councils

Consumers have shifted to digital channels for more complex banking needs and are increasingly using mobile banking for a variety of tasks. Weekly mobile banking usage has grown from 42% to 68% in Australia over the last six years, and American adoption of mobile banking has grown from 59% in 2018 to 79% in 2024. We believe AI adoption will follow the same trajectory: slow beginnings, then rapid growth once trust is established.



The transition to AI in banking is accelerating. While it will soon become a core part of banking, not all consumers are ready to embrace it.

Banks that meet consumers with transparency, the reassurance of support and hybrid models will differentiate themselves in a crowded market.

Trust and transparency: the key to AI's future in finance

In 2026, banks will continue to increase their AI capability and will need to reshape the conversation around trust and capability to increase adoption. American and Canadian consumers are most comforted by regular audits and assessments to ensure accuracy and risk limitation, with 32% and 30% respectively, highlighting the need. Similarly, Australians would be encouraged to use AI with their bank if they were more confident in the advice they receive from AI solutions (23%), meaning

banks will need to publish how they ensure accuracy and understanding of personal financial situations. Transparency is also key for consumers in Singapore (34%), Malaysia (34%) and Hong Kong (29%), who say clear explanations of AI's benefits and limits would boost adoption. Banks will also need to provide the option for human assistance alongside AI integration - 1 in 5 Australian consumers find the duality of digital and human assistance encouraging in increasing AI uptake.



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Trend #1

AI-powered finance: The implications for businesses



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Artificial intelligence is no longer a distant innovation for SMEs; it is part of their everyday operations. In 2023, just 1 in 10 UK SMEs (10%) had no concerns about using AI in financial services. By 2025, this figure surged to over 1 in 4 (27%) , with expectations of further growth in 2026.

Canadians remain more cautious; fewer than 1 in 5 SMEs (18%) are fully supportive, with 1 in 4 (27%) comfortable with AI for only routine tasks. As comfort grows, so does scrutiny. SMEs increasingly recognise AI's potential to improve operational efficiency and reduce costs, yet concerns persist, particularly

Source: RFI Global SME Councils

around data security and the loss of human interaction. The latter is cited by 25% of UK SMEs, and by 60% in Canada. Meanwhile, 38% of Australian SMEs believe that AI chatbots would never be able to replicate human interaction.

For financial institutions, building trust through transparency is essential. That means clearly communicating to SMEs about how AI is used, what outcomes it delivers, and understanding where human expertise remains vital. In a landscape of rapid technological change, clarity, control and trust will define the winners.

Trend #2

Digital user experience (UX): The key battleground for customer loyalty

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Digital user experiences are evolving at an extraordinary speed. Innovation is no longer restricted to local enhancements but reflects a global ecosystem of banks demonstrating regional strengths.

Each new capability shows how design is being harnessed to unlock new revenue streams and reduce operating costs across financial services markets.

Mobile has now overtaken online banking as the main interface for financial management, and for many consumers, **the app is the bank**. Insights from our iSky platform, which tracks thousands of real consumer and business interactions with banking apps worldwide, help us to interpret these developments and understand how customer needs are evolving.

And the picture is changing fast. We're seeing a wave of innovation in areas that matter most to customers' security and control.

The winners aren't always the largest global players; it is often smaller players that assemble a nimble toolkit built around three ideas that work beautifully together: virtual accounts, virtual cards and smart automations, wrapped in security that customers can see and control.

Across markets, leading institutions and smaller challengers are redefining what a best-in-class digital experience means, with standout examples in every region.

Security features are gaining prominence.

The ability to temporarily lock or disable a card with card locks has gone up 13.8% over the past two years as security becomes more important to customers. And one of the most highly sought-after features globally, the ability to cancel and replace a card, has also continued to grow steadily, averaging just under 3% year-on-year growth over the past 24 months.

1

Trust and data security are being made visible.

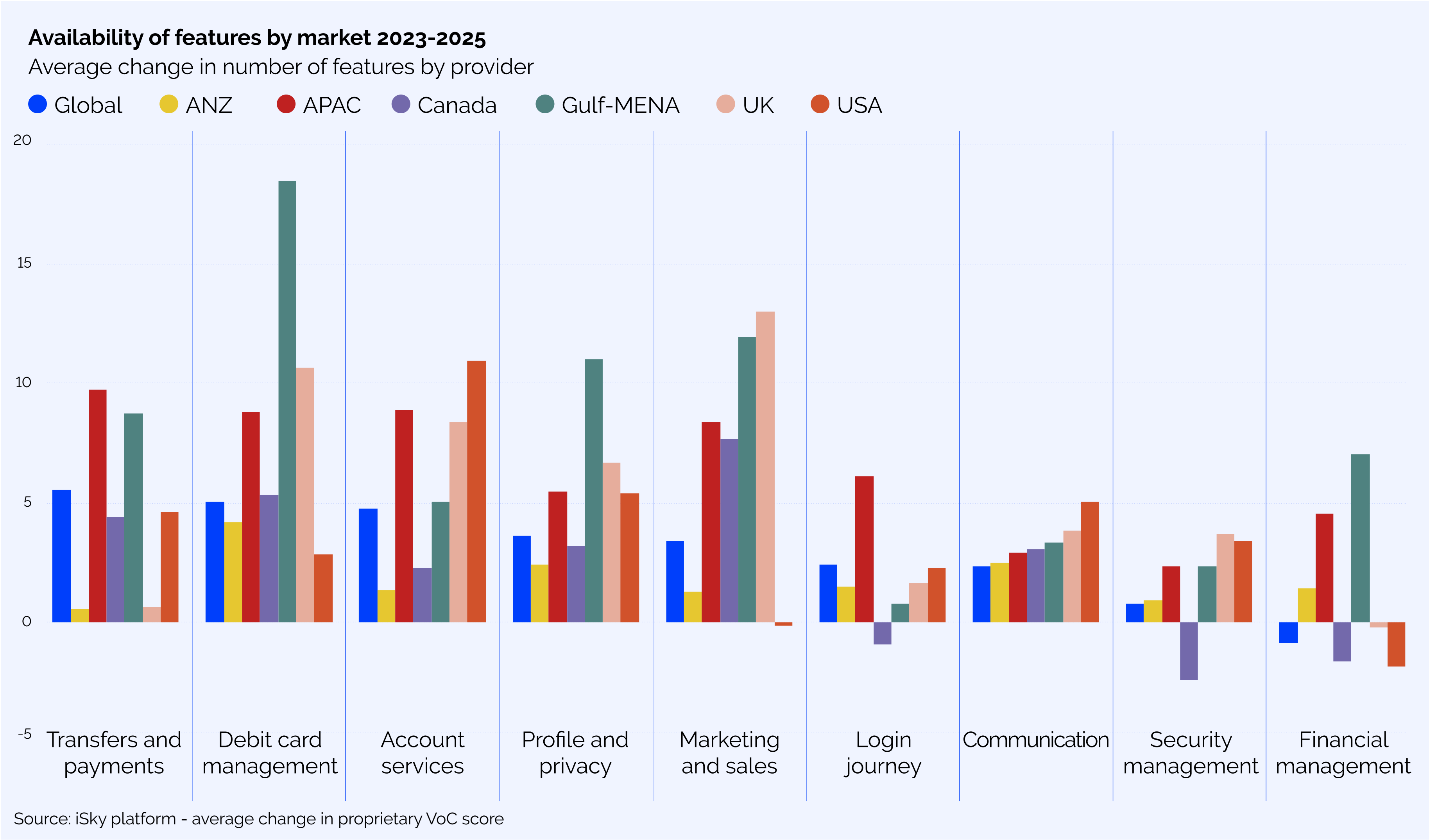
Customer-controlled features that build confidence and relevance are empowering customers to manage their profile and digital footprint. In the past two years, 16% of banks globally have incorporated profile or account closing features in-app, while over 11% have added the ability to mask personal information on the interface for the first time.

2

Increased customer control.

We've also seen an increase in the ability of customers to view card details in-app over the last 12 months. In the last two years, over 10% of the hundreds of apps we benchmark have added the ability for customers to view card details in-app.

3



Across over 200 banking apps worldwide, we've seen a vast increase in the number of features available, with the biggest growth in debit card management, marketing and sales, privacy and payments.

These changes reveal a clear shift: banks are no longer just providing digital access - they're designing digital empowerment.

us



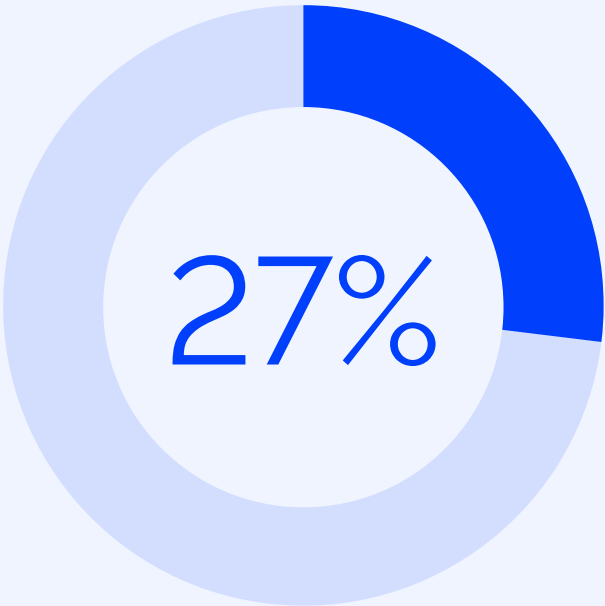
Security hubs are widespread among major banks, blending risk management controls with education and advice on emerging threats. The ability for customers to view login or interaction history is up over 15% in two years. Chase has pushed beyond core banking into areas like travel, equity trading and automated money management, mirroring the diversification seen in UK challengers.

Source: iSky platform



Security remains a significant focus in Asia. Leading Hong Kong banks are deploying pages that allow customers to track and respond to events like contact changes, statement downloads, or new payees. In Singapore, banks have introduced locks on funds that prevent customers and potential fraudsters from transacting until after additional verification.

The region also led in rolling out QR code payments, with over 27% of banks incorporating payment pre-login for customers.

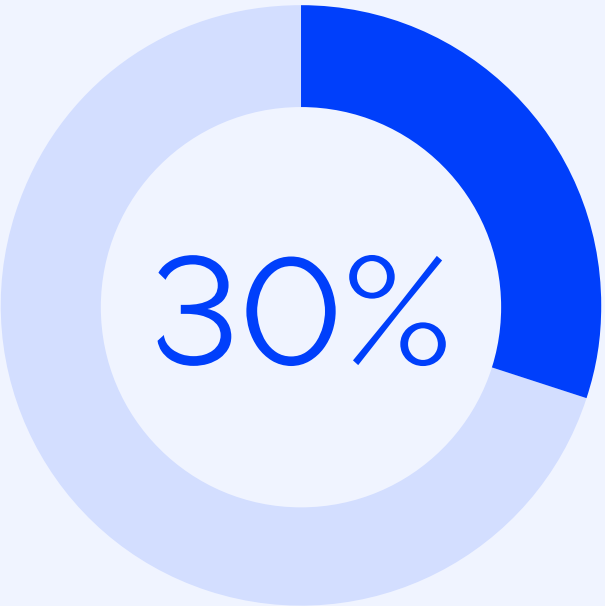


Source: iSky platform



Neo-banks are setting the pace. Revolut has expanded into tradeable assets, crypto, shares, precious metals and multinational currencies, while building rewards and socialised banking features. Monzo has leaned into security, with innovations like Trusted Contacts and scam protection. Starling continues to refine its family-friendly model through virtual cards and accounts (Spaces). Product applications have been a strong focus, with application availability via mobile app increasing by over 30% in the past two years across product categories.

In-app product application journeys are up 30% in two years



Source: iSky platform





35% of providers have introduced card locking in-app for the first time in the last two years.

Cards have been a focus, with Canadian institutions lagging global peers in this critical UX area. Over 35% of providers have introduced card locking in-app for the first time in two years. Communications is an area of comparative strength - CIBC's Request Centre stands out, offering transparency on non-straight-through processing requests and reducing costs. Rewards and benefits are up 29% in 2 years, as providers offer these elements without extra fees. Accessibility tools and information services are also up 22.3%.

Source: iSky platform



15% of institutions have introduced enhanced features and information pages.

Accessibility and customisation are growing priorities. Over 15% of institutions have introduced enhanced features and information pages. Payment innovation and UX customisation remain in focus, with enhancing payment journeys through protective features like recipient verification and scam alerts. Enhancements include PayID, Osko and PayTo continue to gain ground. Westpac now enables customers to switch account types or fees without closing accounts, and over 12% of institutions have introduced card limit controls to the app for the first time.

Source: iSky platform

What's next for 2026?

We are entering an era where providers that excel in service will control the customer relationship, building aggregated portals for financial services and communications. These channels become trusted gateways for engagement and loyalty. For laggards, differentiation will narrow to product, fees and rates, triggering a margin-eroding race to the bottom. The next twelve months will be pivotal, determining which providers seize the opportunity to lead on service, and which are left to compete on price.

The next twelve months will be pivotal, determining which providers seize the opportunity to lead on service.



Nine in ten apps now offer multi-factor authentication

Trend #2

Digital UX: The implications for businesses



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In addition to the personal banking trends highlighted, commercial digital experiences are undergoing rapid transformation.

Across 55 corporate and SME web channels benchmarked, and a comparable set of mobile apps, the strongest growth has been in workflow automation, payment security and administrative control.

The ability for administrators to manage user access and authorisations online has increased 19% since 2023, while tools supporting same-day or batch payment approvals have grown

14%. Security management features, spanning biometrics, token login and device recognition, are up 18%, with almost nine in ten apps now offering multi-factor authentication. Audit-trail and activity-log tools, once niche, are now present in nearly 60% of commercial interfaces, rising 11% in two years.

Collectively, these changes point to a sector rapidly professionalising its digital capabilities: shifting from transactional gateways to integrated command centres that give finance teams stronger oversight, security and control.

Source: iSky platform

Trend #3

The next chapter for neobanks: From growth to value

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After a decade of explosive growth, neobanks are entering a new phase, marked not by sheer customer acquisition but by deepening engagement and delivering sustainable profitability

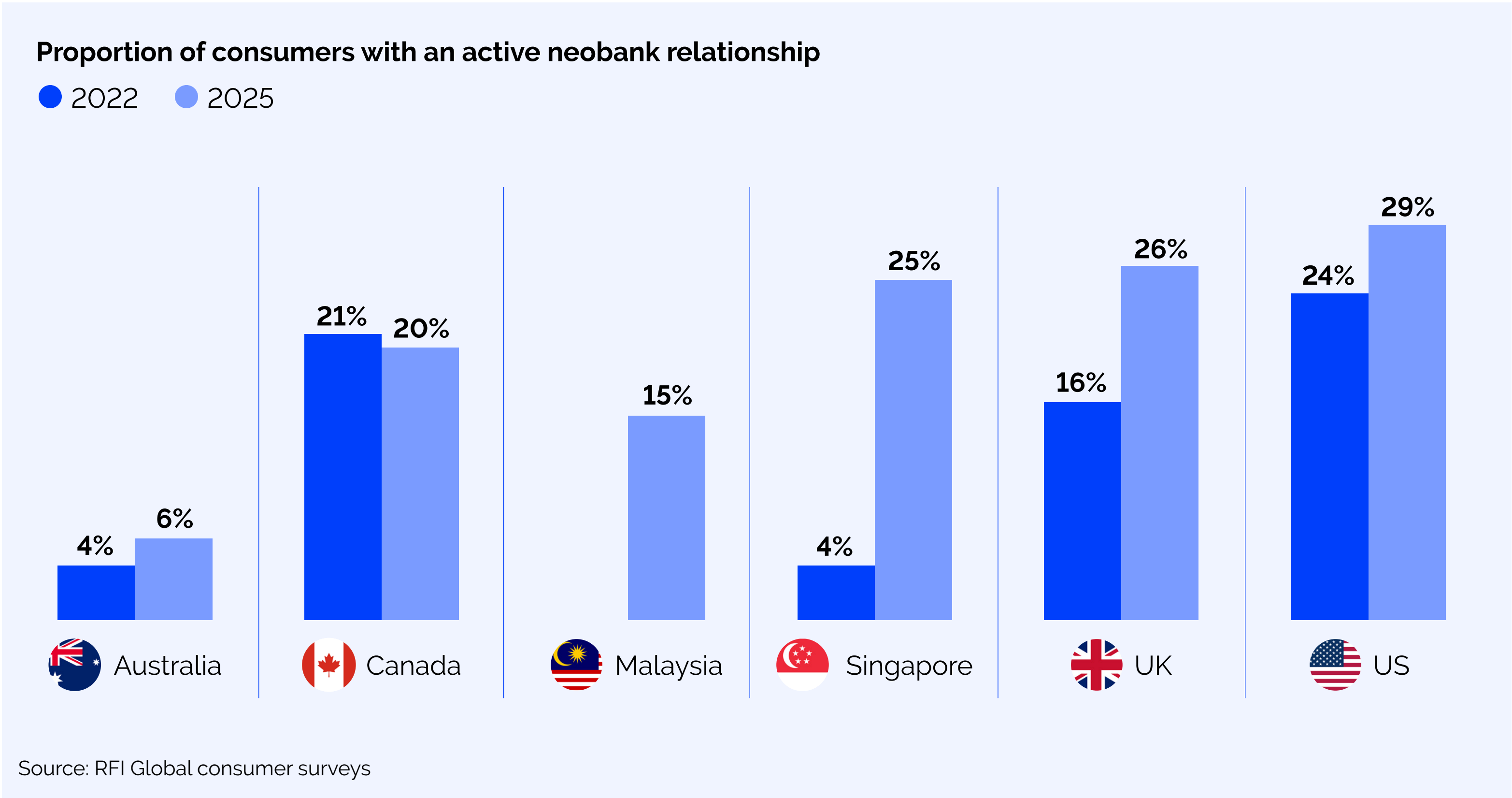
In 2026, we expect this shift in strategy to accelerate and reshape the competitive landscape.

Over the past ten years, neobanks around the world have captured consumer attention with sleek mobile-first platforms, seamless onboarding, innovative products and lower fee, if not fee-free propositions. Our data shows that 26% of UK consumers now have an active relationship with a neobank, ahead of Canada (20%) and on par with the US (29%).

 **UK**

UK neobanks are moving firmly into profitability. Our data shows their share of primary banking relationships increased from 3.5% to 5.9% between 2022 and mid-2025, a 75% increase . Monzo's first annual profit in FY24 showed deposits up 88% and revenue more than doubling*. Revolut continues to scale globally while deepening engagement.

Source: RFI Global Orion, UK consumer survey



Trend #3 **The next chapter for neobanks**

Initially, their focus was often singular: scale fast. The early playbook prioritised exponential growth in customer base, while profitability remained elusive, leaving most neobanks operating at a loss. This is now changing fast.

Today, leading neobanks are shifting their key performance indicators from simple acquisition metrics to profitability, customer engagement and cross-sell ratios. The emphasis is now on monetisation through additional products, subscriptions and premium services.

Revolut, now Europe's most valuable fintech, exemplifies this shift. According to its 2024 Annual Report*, in 2024, its customer base grew 38% to 52.5 million globally and customer balances surged 66% to \$38 billion. Revenues rose 72% to \$4 billion and net profit hit \$1 billion. Its CEO Nik Storonsky noted: "critically, we (also) saw customers engaging more deeply by adopting a wider range of our services... this powerful combination directly fueled our record growth".



Monzo, a standout in the UK, reported its first annual profit in 2024**. While £15 million profit might sound modest, its engagement metrics tell a powerful story: customer deposits rose by 88% year on year to £11.2 billion and gross revenue more than doubled to £880 million.

A key driver of engagement is the expansion of product offerings beyond payments and deposits. This strategy is evident across markets, from SoFi's expansion into lending, investing and insurance in the US, to Hong Kong's virtual banks moving into wealth management. In the UK, neobanks are similarly diversifying, reinforcing their role as full-service providers.

Our data highlights the impact of this shift: neobanks' share of primary banking relationships in the US nearly doubled from 4.6% in 2022 to 8.7% in 2024. In the UK, it rose from 3.5% to 5.9% between 2022 and mid-2025. Among UK consumers who started their current main banking relationship in the past three years (15% of the market), neobanks now collectively hold over 20% market share.



US



US neobanks are maturing rapidly. SoFi has diversified into lending, investing and insurance, reporting consistent profitability. Neobanks' share of primary banking relationships nearly doubled from 4.6% in 2022 to 8.7% in 2024, reflecting deeper customer engagement and trust.

Source: RFI Global MacroMonitor, US household survey



CANADA



1 in 5 Canadian consumers hold an account with a digital-only bank

a slight decline from the end of 2022, indicating limited momentum. The two largest players, Tangerine and Simplii, are both owned by major incumbent banks. Lower fees remain the primary competitive advantage driving the appeal of digital-only banks in Canada and the leading reason consumers choose them as their primary banking provider.

Source: RFI Global Canadian Consumer Council

 **AUSTRALIA**

Australia's neobank wave has largely receded. Of the challengers granted banking licenses in 2018 and 2019, three have exited or been swallowed by larger players (Volt Bank, Xinja and 86 400). A small number of players remain e.g. Up (owned by Bendigo & Adelaide Bank) and Judo (focused on small businesses). Regulatory caution and consolidation have reshaped the landscape, with no new independent neobanks emerging.

Source: RFI Global Australian Consumer Council

 **APAC**

In Hong Kong, virtual banks are narrowing losses and expanding into wealth management. ZA Bank became the first to report a monthly profit in 2024, with deposits and transaction volumes rising sharply. The region's neobanks are focusing on customer value and product diversification to drive sustainable growth. Meanwhile, neobanks in Malaysia and Singapore, which launched only within the past four years, have experienced exponential growth in their customer bases.

Source: RFI Global APAC Consumer Councils

Several strategic changes underpin this move toward maturity:

Product diversification: neobanks are rapidly expanding into savings, credit, wealth management, SME banking and insurance

Customer engagement: money management tools, new product solutions, loyalty programmes and lifestyle integrations are driving usage and retention

Strategic partnerships: collaborations with other alternative and traditional providers are enhancing product propositions and customer benefits faster than in-house development (e.g. Monzo's partnership with BlackRock to offer investment solutions)

Technology leverage: AI-driven personalisation and embedded finance are becoming key differentiators

This strategic pivot towards deeper engagement and sustainable profitability is now universal, even if market maturity varies.

2026: The year of maturity for neobanks

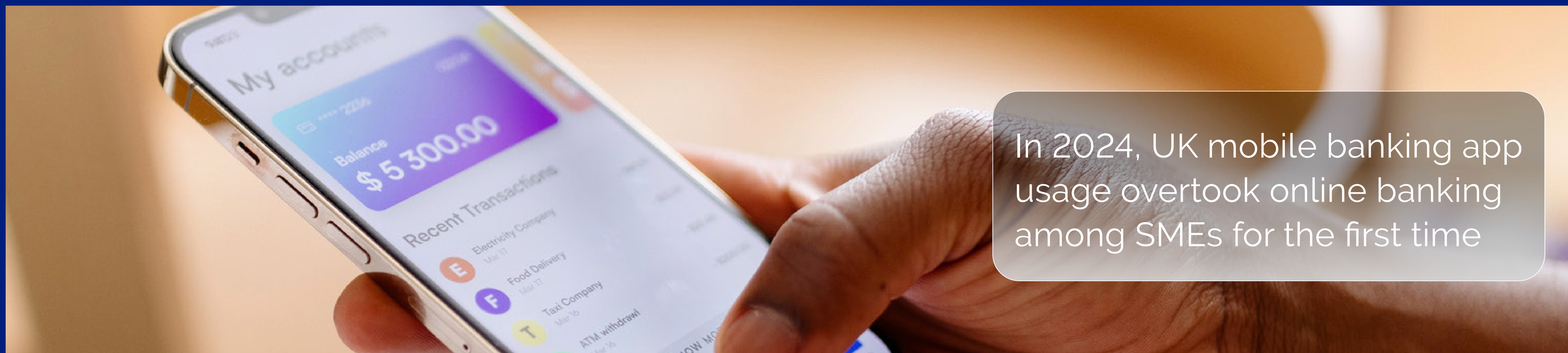
As we look towards 2026, the trend is clear - neobanks are no longer just disruptors used for secondary relationships or transactional perks - they are increasingly evolving into full-service financial institutions.

We believe this shift will accelerate, driven by consumer demand for value, innovation and integrated financial experiences, as well as growing trust in these providers. As Revolut and Monzo prove, profitability and rapid growth can coexist. In 2026, neobanks that master both will move from challengers to true rivals of established providers.

Neobanks are no longer just disruptors used for secondary relationships or transactional perks - they are increasingly evolving into full-service financial institutions.



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Trend #3

Neobanks: The implications for businesses



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Fintechs are rewriting the rules of SME banking, and mobile is the new battleground. Half of UK SMEs (49%) and two-fifths of Hong Kong businesses (38%) now hold a business banking product with a fintech, up from just one-third (30%) five years ago. Our data shows that this surge is driven by frictionless onboarding, strong digital capabilities and constant innovation.

The knock-on effect of fintech is clear. In 2024, UK mobile banking app usage overtook online banking for the first time, a trend that's continuing in 2025, and we've seen this trend in other markets. Over 1 in 2 of UK SMEs (54%)

Source: RFI Global SME Councils

now use mobile banking apps weekly, with Canada and the US close behind at 45%. Meanwhile, Malaysia leads the way, with 60% engaging weekly.

In this mobile-first landscape, the winners will be those delivering personalised, insight-driven experiences. Over 1 in 2 SMEs (52%) crave better personalisation from their mobile banking app. Tailored product recommendations, relevant business insights, and predictive tools will define the next generation of SME banking apps.

For fintechs and incumbents alike, the message is clear: ease of use is expected, and personalisation will be the differentiator for 2026 and beyond.

Trend #4

Cybersecurity:

Fraud has evolved,
but have banks?



In June 2025, the US Department of Justice announced the biggest US crypto seizure to date, with \$225 million seized from crypto scams known as pig butchering*.

Financial fraud isn't new, but the way it's carried out has changed beyond recognition. From ancient insurance scams in Greek ports to Ponzi schemes on Wall Street, fraudsters have always chased opportunity. The difference today is scale, speed, sophistication and AI. Technology has turned fraud into a global, real-time threat.

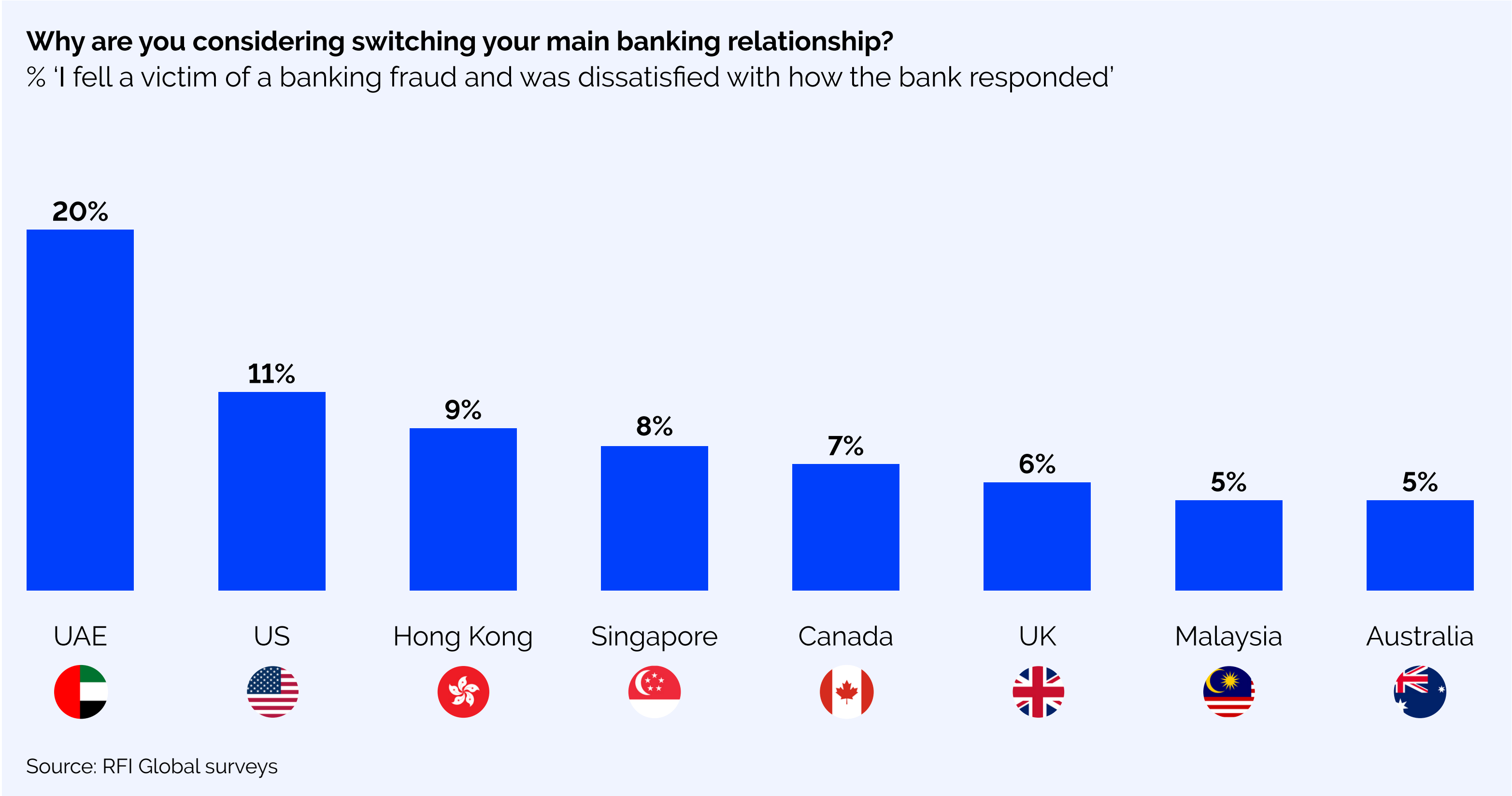
Our data shows the impact fraud has on customer retention, with 5-20% of customers across markets stating their bank's response to fraud is a reason they are considering switching their primary bank.

 **UK**

39% feel the security features for authenticating the payment is the #1 consideration when choosing a payment method for online purchases.

Source: RFI Global Orion, UK consumer survey

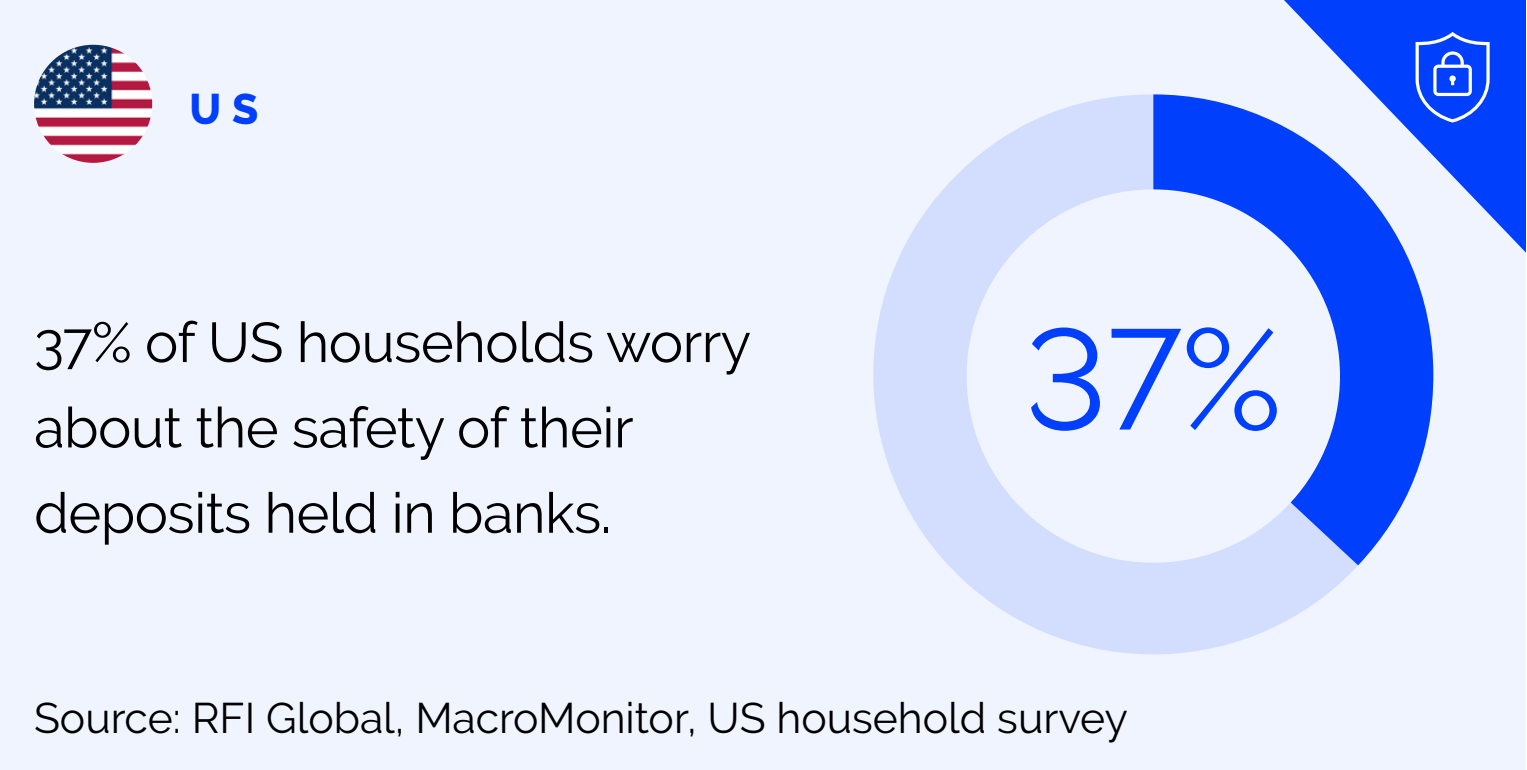
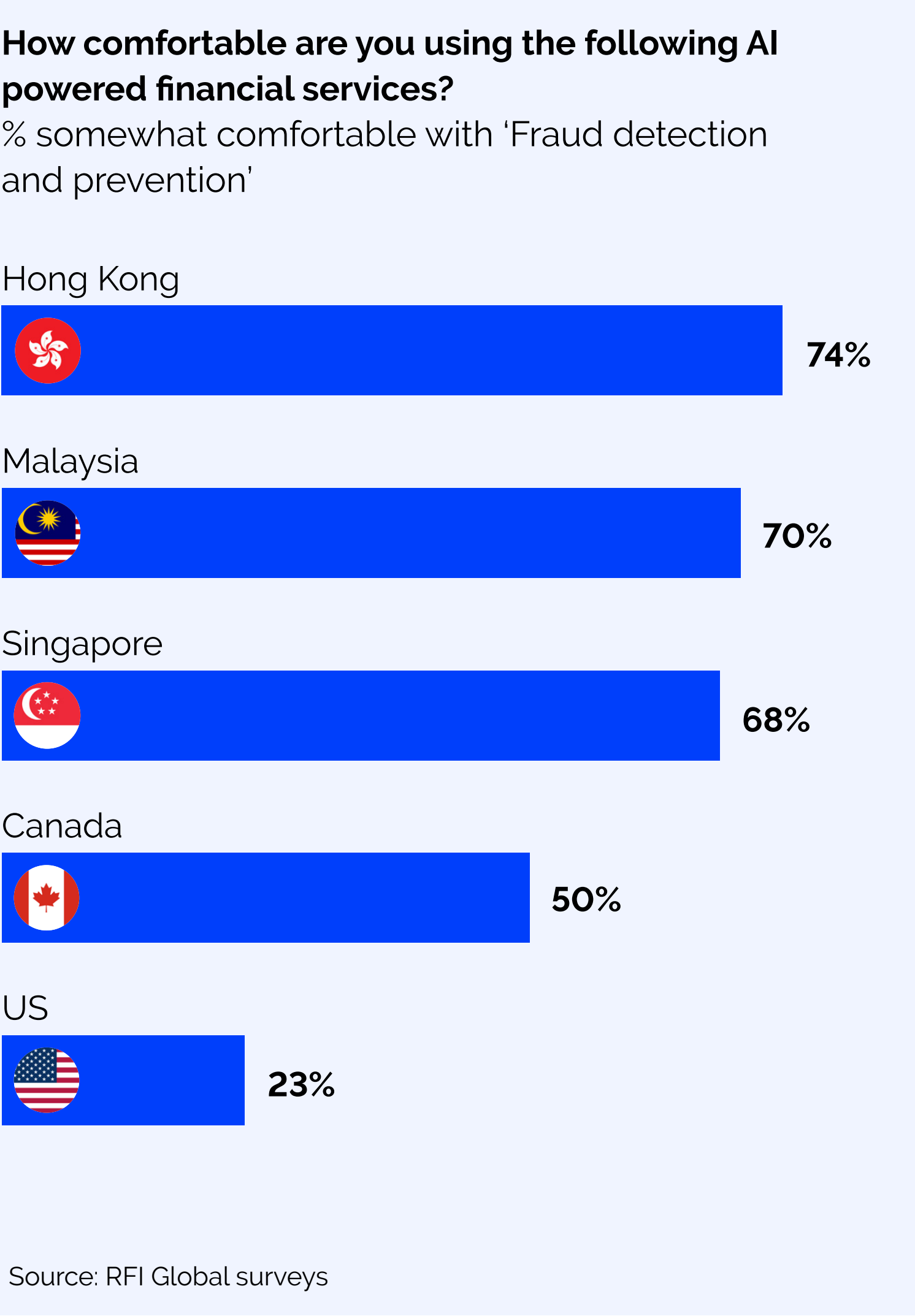




UK bank, NatWest, reported that AI-powered fraud is the third fastest-growing fraud consumers are exposed to, after fake parcel delivery and social media marketplace scams. Voice cloning, deepfake endorsements and synthetic IDs can be created in minutes. Fraudsters no longer need to be hackers. Fraud kits and 'cybercrime-as-a-service' platforms are making sophisticated scams accessible to anyone with a laptop and a motive.

This presents a brutal challenge for financial institutions. Traditional defences, like passwords, one-time codes and even voice recognition are being outpaced. As OpenAI's Sam Altman bluntly warned this year: "AI has fully defeated most of the ways people authenticate currently."

The rise of synthetic fraud is a prime example. Unlike classic ID theft, it combines real and fake details to build new personas, complete with AI-generated passports and social media footprints. Detecting them requires more than checking documents; it demands behavioural and link analysis and biometrics that can't be faked.



So, where does this leave consumers and financial institutions as we head towards 2026?

Fraud detection has always been a data problem, but the volume and variety required is exploding. Financial institutions need to blend bureau checks, transaction histories, device signals and even subtle behavioural biometrics like typing rhythm. Done well, these checks are invisible to customers, with no friction unless anomalies appear. But if done badly, they create bottlenecks that frustrate users and erode trust. We strongly believe artificial intelligence (AI) will play a key role in delivering fraud detection solutions. Our data shows that Asian consumers are most receptive to financial institutions using AI to aid fraud detection and prevention, and US consumers are most concerned.

One institution's dataset is rarely enough to spot organised crime. Authorised push payment (APP) scams, money mule

networks and crypto laundering are only revealed when data is shared across institutions and supported by data from telecoms companies, tech giants and regulators. In 2026, we will see more cross-industry platforms pooling fraud intelligence in real time.

Compliance pressure will further accelerate cross-institution and cross-industry cooperation. The UK provides a leading example of regulatory pushback against fraud. Since September 2025, the UK's Economic Crime and Corporate Transparency Act has been imposing heavy penalties on firms without adequate fraud and anti-money laundering (AML) safeguards. Crypto platforms, telecoms companies and even tech providers will be in scope. The message is clear: fighting fraud isn't just a bank's problem anymore.

**Fraud has evolved.
Criminals are ready for 2026 -
are financial institutions?**

While efforts are being made, the big question is whether financial institutions can evolve as fast as the criminals. Fraudsters will always be inventive, but financial institutions have a unique edge: trusted customer relationships and access to unparalleled data. If they can harness AI to detect anomalies, share intelligence across industries, and balance friction with trust, they can turn the tide.



73% of Australian consumers expect fraud alerts and transaction monitoring to be available within their mobile banking app

Source: RFI Global Australian consumer Council



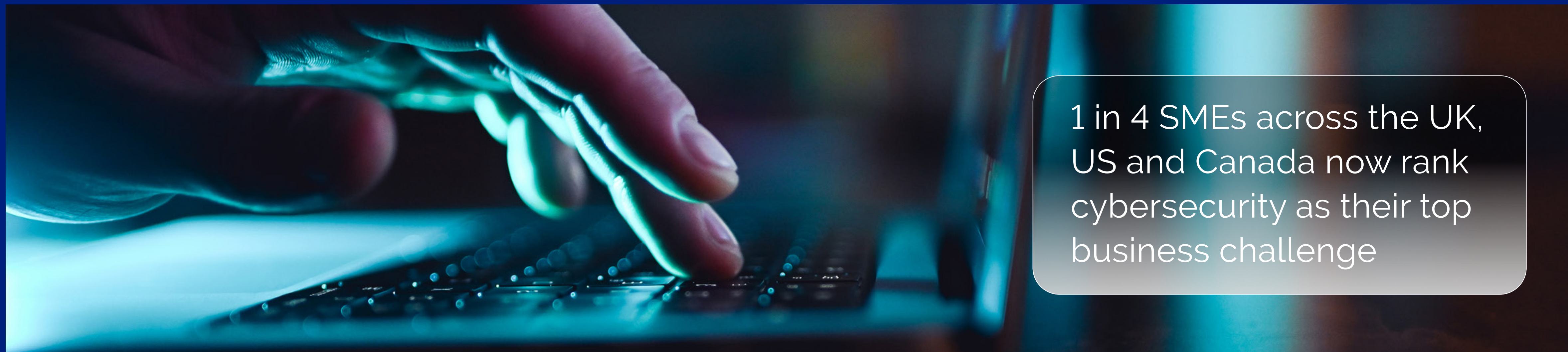
Under a fifth of consumers in APAC are wholly satisfied with the security features of their primary bank's app

Singapore (17%), Hong Kong (15%).

Source: RFI Global APAC consumer Councils



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Trend #4

Cybersecurity: The implications for businesses



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Cybersecurity is no longer a back-office concern for businesses; it's a frontline risk. The threat has evolved rapidly as SMEs deepen their reliance on digital channels. In 2025, in the UK alone, major brands including Jaguar Land Rover, Marks & Spencer and Co-op experienced cyberattacks that halted operations and exposed sensitive customer data. The ripple effects have hit thousands of SMEs in their supply chains.

Our data shows that 1 in 4 SMEs across the UK (24%), US (24%), Canada (23%) and over a third in Australia (36%) now rank cybersecurity as their top business

challenge. Yet many still lack the tools, knowledge, or capacity to respond effectively.

Financial institutions have a vital role to play by offering cybersecurity and fraud prevention tools to help SMEs actively defend against threats. Over 1 in 4 SMEs in the UK (28%), US (28%), Canada (29%), Hong Kong (29%) and Malaysia (28%) want their financial institution to offer these tools - the second most desired value-add after accounting solutions. In a climate where cyberattacks are a growing threat, financial institutions must help equip SMEs with the defences they need.

Source: RFI Global SME Councils

Trend #5

Wealth in 2026: Unlocking fee-based growth as affluent investments rise

RFI GLOBAL



In 2026, as central banks across major economies shift toward more accommodative monetary policies, lower interest rates will compress net interest margins across the global banking sector.

This structural pressure will accelerate a strategic pivot: banks will increasingly rely on fee-based income to sustain profitability.

Our latest data reveals a global resurgence in investment intent as affluent consumers seek to make their money work harder. Singapore's investors are leading the way, with 41% of affluent consumers open to reallocating funds from savings into portfolios as rates decrease.

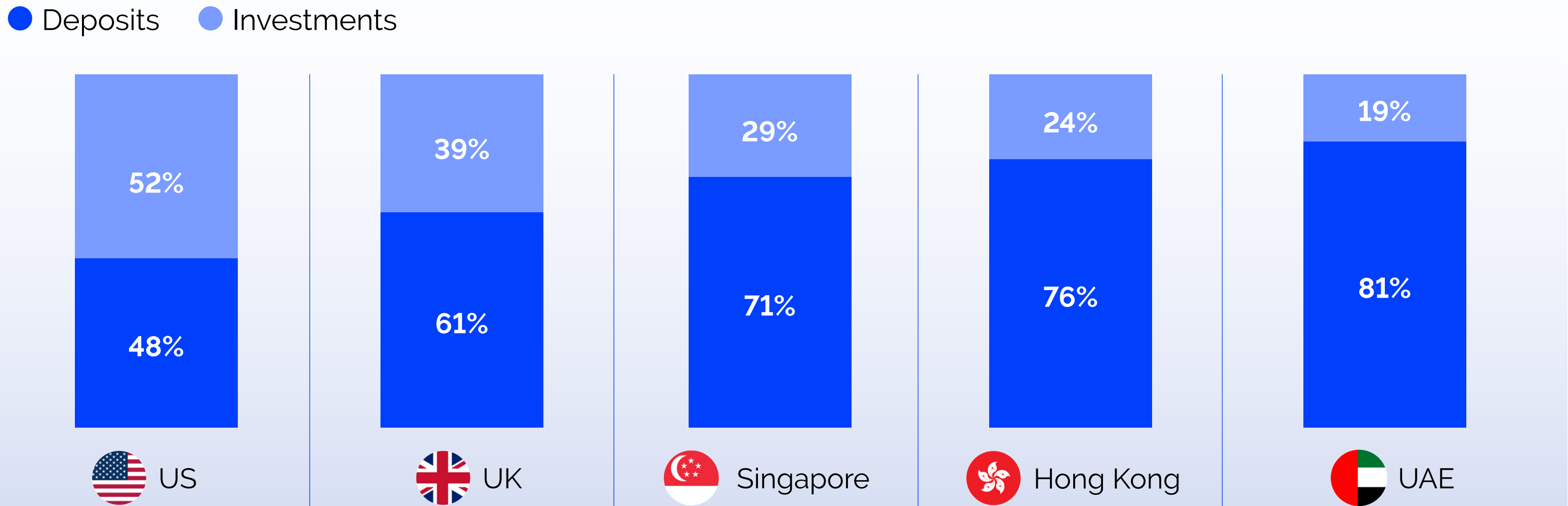
In the US, investments now account for nearly a third of all household financial assets (31%), reflecting a steady shift toward wealth creation beyond traditional savings. A similar trend is evident in the UK, where 31% of affluent consumers plan to pursue higher returns over the next year, and in the UAE, where 24% of affluent consumers are likely to take up a new wealth offering. In Australia, more than one in three high-net-worth consumers are planning to deploy additional funds into new investments.

As investment appetite rises globally, three critical challenges limit banks' ability to capture fee-based growth:

1 Deposit dominance prevents wallet conversion

Despite rising investment intent, our Share of Wallet data shows that in Singapore, the UK, Hong Kong and the UAE, approximately 70% of affluent consumers' liquid assets remain parked in low-yield deposit products. Behavioural inertia and risk aversion remain key barriers.

Assets under management (AUM) split between deposits and investments



Source: RFI Global consumer surveys

2 Cross-border blind spots limit proposition design

Wealth is flowing across markets, from the UAE to India, Mainland China to Hong Kong, and Hong Kong to London and Singapore, while the US remains the preferred market for equity investments. Yet motivations vary. Without understanding why customers move money, banks risk offering generic solutions that fail to resonate.

3 Non-bank competition is intensifying

In markets like the US, UK and Singapore, digital platforms, brokers, fintechs and neo-banks are capturing a growing share of investor activity - offering sleek interfaces, lower fees and tailored products.

 **US**



Mutual fund investment is surging in the US and is fuelled by High Net Worth households' investment activity. HNW households hold \$8.06 trillion in mutual funds, up from \$6.02 trillion in 2022 and \$3.49 trillion in 2020.

Source: RFI Global MacroMonitor, US household survey



 **UK**



Mass Affluent consumers lead the charge toward active wealth strategies, with 31% planning to make their money work harder over the next 12 months. This intent outpaces other segments, signalling strong demand for higher returns and reinforcing the need for banks to deliver tailored investment propositions.

% of those who plan to 'make my money work harder' in the next 12 month

Lower Mass Market	13%
Upper Mass Market	22%
Emerging Affluent	28%
Mass Affluent	31%

Source: RFI Global Orion, UK consumer survey



70% of Mass Affluent assets remain in low-yield deposits. This imbalance highlights a major conversion opportunity for banks: shifting funds into higher-return portfolios through education, advisory and personalised experiences as rate cuts reshape wealth strategies.

Source: RFI Global Singapore Consumer Council



Mass Affluent customers in the Mainland China–Hong Kong corridor prioritise access and returns. Nearly half (47%) hold products in Hong Kong to gain better investment returns, while 39% seek portfolio diversification and 37% value access to banking and investment products. Understanding these motivations is critical for designing competitive cross-border propositions.

Source: RFI Global Hong Kong consumer Council



Nearly a quarter of Australia's HNWs are planning to invest between \$100K–\$500K in new opportunities. This signals strong confidence in market growth and a readiness to diversify portfolios. For wealth managers, it's a prime moment to engage, advise, and capture momentum in the evolving investment landscape.

Source: RFI Global Australian Consumer Council

Preparing for 2026: The strategic imperatives for wealth growth

We believe fee-based income will grow, but only for banks that get three things right: conversion, visibility and experience. As wealth becomes more mobile, digital and diversified, institutions must evolve from custodians of cash to architects of their customers' financial futures.

Winning in 2026 will require propositions that reflect customer intent across borders, while staying ahead of accelerating competition

from non-bank players. Affluent consumers are increasingly building portfolios beyond traditional banks, so incumbents will need to modernise the customer experience and expand digital ecosystems to remain relevant.

The institutions that deliver seamless, personalised, and insight-driven offerings will not only diversify revenue streams but also deepen engagement, positioning themselves to thrive in an increasingly margin-constrained environment.

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Over 1 in 4 SMEs globally intend to expand into new markets or grow international sales in the next year.

Trend #5

Growth: The implications for businesses



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Despite economic headwinds, global ambition among SMEs is strong. In 2025, over 1 in 4 SMEs globally intend to expand into new markets or grow international sales in the next year. APAC SMEs lead the way, with 43% of Hong Kong SMEs and 38% of Malaysian SMEs looking to do so. UK SMEs slightly outperform the average (26%), while the US (23%) and Canada (20%) trail at 23% and 20%, respectively. Even amid trade uncertainty, existing SMEs remain resilient - 28% of UK SMEs and 23% of Canadian SMEs plan to expand their cross-border operations.

Source: RFI Global SME Councils

This ambition underscores the vital role SMEs play as the backbone of global economies. However, as they scale internationally, their expectations of financial institutions are evolving just as fast. The role of financial institutions is shifting, from transactional facilitators to strategic growth partners.

Over 1 in 3 SMEs in the UK (34%) and Canada (38%) with international ambitions seek insights on business and industry trends in new markets, reliable information tailored to their specific needs, and tools that simplify cross-border payments and compliance. The winning financial institutions will be those that act not just as service providers, but as strategic enablers of global SME growth.

Conclusion

2025 has marked a turning point for the global financial services industry, where mobile wallets have become mainstream, mobile apps are overtaking online banking and financial institutions are moving from experimentation to execution with AI.

Trust has re-emerged as the defining currency of finance. Whether it's building customer confidence in AI-driven services or protecting against increasingly sophisticated fraud; transparency, security and education are now core to customer relationships.

For neobanks, the era of hypergrowth is giving way to one focused on value in most markets, deepening engagement, driving profitability and sustaining differentiation. Incumbents that once trailed with digital innovation are now catching up fast, using data and scale and partnerships to deliver more seamless and meaningful experiences.

Wealth management is also at an inflection point. As consumers rebalance from deposits to diversified portfolios, fee-based growth is becoming the new benchmark for success. Yet this potential will only be realised by institutions that can overcome behavioural inertia, improve cross-border visibility and integrate advice across digital platforms.

Digital experience remains the unifying thread. From onboarding to servicing, consumers expect simplicity, speed and personalisation. The next evolution in digital banking will be defined not by new apps, but by intelligent, frictionless ecosystems that anticipate needs and inspire trust.

2026 will be defined by the intersection of trust, technology and transformation - a year when digital maturity and customer-centricity will separate leaders from laggards. Success will belong to financial institutions that combine innovation with integrity, using

AI responsibly and delivering experiences that feel both human and high-tech.

The insights shared in this booklet draw on RFI Global's interviews with 200,000 consumers, 60,000 businesses and thousands of real interactions with banking apps worldwide each year. To stay ahead in 2026 and beyond, speak to your local RFI Global expert to discuss how these trends can shape your strategy and help you unlock new growth opportunities.



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Get in touch with your local expert to find out more

We'd love to discuss the trends and future developments in the financial services market with you. Please get in touch with your regional expert to arrange a call.

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Alex leads RFI Global's product team, with over 20 years of experience in financial services research. A proven leader in product innovation, he drives the product delivery and development of solutions. He has launched, maintained and enhanced a multitude of industry-shaping products during this time.



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Intelligence to bank on

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